CHAPTER 15

THE AUSSIES

2 March 2003

ENGLAND vs AUSTRALIA, 2003 Cricket World Cup, *Gqeberha*

England 204/8; Australia 208/8

Australia won by 2 wickets

Australia innings: **J Anderson 9–0–66–0**

The downside of sudden expectation, of quickly becoming known and being part of an opponent's preparations, landed during that same World Cup. The surprise on those Pakistani legends' faces, looking back as I ran towards them celebrating, trying to work out who I was, was gone from then on in. It didn't matter what level of cricket I was playing now; from Burnley to Brisbane, I wasn't going to be running in again with that outsider's sense of abandon. And by the time we met Australia at Port Elizabeth, we had become handicapped and in desperate need of a win because we refused to play in Zimbabwe during Mugabe's reign. A letter had come to the ECB promising to send us 'back to Britain in wooden coffins'. So, it felt like a good idea not to go really, however badly we wanted to finally win a World Cup.

Honestly, I had my suspicions about how far we were going to go in the World Cup anyway when sitting in the dressing room, with Alec Stewart talking to Ian Blackwell. 'I think we have got a really good chance in this tournament,' Alec is saying. 'And it's my last tournament, I really want to win it.' Blackwell nods. 'So, make sure that you eat and drink well and stay healthy because it really could be the difference.' Blackwell nods again and, as if reassuring Stewart, putting his mind to rest, says, 'Don't worry, mate,